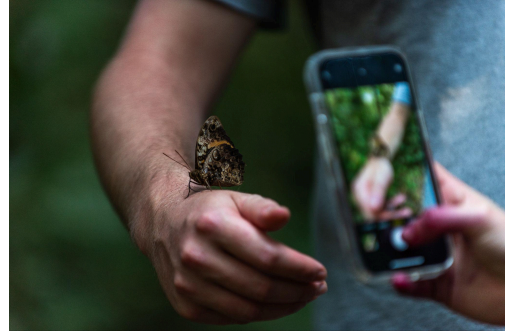


Chapter 6 – Becoming One With Nature

When we first arrived at the eco-lodge, we were merely adjusting to the rainforest. But with each passing day, we grew more at ease. On the first hike, I envied the butterfly that had landed daintily on our guide's shoulder. By the third day, I too became one of the lucky ones chosen by a butterfly. The sensation of being “drunk from” by a butterfly—feeding on the salt of my sweat—was strangely wonderful. It felt like a blessing, as if I had finally become a tiny part of the ecosystem.



As humans, placed at the top of the food chain, I felt a rare thrill at Tres Chimbadás Lake when I managed to catch two notorious Amazon piranhas, the only person in the group who succeeded. I held a primitive fishing rod—just a wooden pole, a thin line, and a metal hook. With a piece of chicken as bait, I tossed it into the water, and within moments the keen-scented fish arrived. They swarmed fiercely, tearing at the bait with lightning speed. The moment I sensed a tug, I had to yank sideways with force, hooking the slippery creature before it escaped. Lose focus for just a moment, and you became the one feeding them. My heart raced the entire time. Unlike regular fishing, this felt like a raw contest between myself and nature—a thrilling, primal kind of tension.

